inspection circuit every five years to preach the dhamma, the usual Ashokan favourites being enjoined—proper behaviour towards various classes of people and animal life, respect to be shown to parents and elders, liberality with friends as well as, importantly, to persons with differing religious inclinations. The injunction against slaughtering all living beings —presumably animals, birds, and fish—was naturally a strong recommendation in this idea of the moral life. Whereas Minor Rock Edict II had underlined the need for proper behaviour towards all as something that 'should' be done, or as an order of the emperor, here it was expected to be preached by his officials so as to earn his subjects personal merit.

> Meritorious is obedience to mother and father.
>
> Meritorious is liberality to friends, acquaintances and relatives and to Shramanas and Brahmanas.
>
> Meritorious is abstention from the slaughter of living beings.

Meritorious is to spend little (and) to store little.[6]

The importance attached to such public instruction of morality resonates with the way that Buddhism had always tried to establish its doctrines, alongside the giving and donating expected of the laity.[7] Yet the conformity with established doctrinal practice does not explain everything: there is an interesting deviation. Shramanas were ascetic renunciants that included but were not limited to Buddhist monks. By alluding to Brahmanas and Shramanas in the same breath, Ashoka extends Buddhist ideas somewhat beyond their normal boundaries into a broader humanism. The espousal of moderation and thrift within the fold of meritorious conduct extends religious morality into administrative duty and state function. Crass materialism and conspicuous consumption are cautioned against, possibly as a veiled warning to affluent citizens who heard his message as also to sections of officialdom. Ashoka does not seem to censure the acquisition of wealth per se, the donation of riches to the deserving perhaps justifying the initial acquisition.